Day One: Model Campfire

Time Allowed

60 Minutes

Teaching Format

Troop presentation

A youth staff member who is skilled in leading campfires assumes the dual roles of session instructor and master of ceremonies.

The instructional presentation at the beginning of the campfire provides guidelines for effective campfire programs. The instructor then becomes a master of ceremonies, introducing staff members whose songs, skits, ceremonies, and other offerings illustrate important concepts of appropriate campfire programs.

As with any good campfire, the staff members who will be involved should make their plans well in advance of the program. The session instructor/master of ceremonies should already know what will be included in the instructional portion of the program. Staff members can then settle on the songs, skits, stories, and other offerings they will present to support key portions of the instructional message.

Learning Objectives

As a result of this session, participants will be able to do the following:

1. Experience a model for running a successful campfire.
2. Explore ways to present an appropriate, enjoyable campfire.
3. Practice effective communication skills.
4. Receive the Scoutmaster's challenge for each patrol to develop its Quest for the Meaning of Leadership.
5. Observe an exemplary presentation by the NYLT youth staff of their Quest for the Meaning of Leadership.
6. Have fun!

Materials Needed

- Campfire Program Planner

Recommended Presenter

Assigned NYLT staff members

Recommended Location

Campfire ring

 © Scouting America. For use in approved NYLT courses only.

Recommended Facility Layout

A campfire setting is ideal, but the program can be conducted in any group setting large enough to accommodate all participants and staff comfortably. Where fire building is appropriate, a wood fire can provide atmosphere for the occasion; however, a fire is not essential to the success of the session.

PRESENTATION OUTLINE

Lighting the Campfire

The master of ceremonies explains how the fire lighting is being conducted, noting both the method used and the intended effects.

Even a method as simple as using matches to ignite the tinder can have elements of showmanship that will make an impression on the audience and set the tone for the program.

> ***Note***: Construct the fire lay early, while the wood and tinder are dry, and cover it with a tarp to protect it from dampness until time for the program.

Opening

The master of ceremonies welcomes everyone and lets the audience know that this campfire is a little different than any they have experienced. It is an opening for the NYLT course. As an instructional campfire, it will also teach youth leaders how to ensure the success of campfires they have with their home units.

The master of ceremonies explains that campfires are fun, but they can be much more. They can offer entertainment, fellowship, and education. Campfires are a chance to practice leadership skills. A campfire can be an ideal time to share inspirational messages.

Planning

The master of ceremonies explains that for a campfire program to be effective, it must be well-planned and practiced ahead of time. The NYLT Participant Notebook has a Campfire Program Planner that might be just what participants need for future campfires. If not, they can develop their own campfire program planner.

A good rule of thumb for planning campfire programs is to follow the fire. Early in the evening when the flames are lively, the program can be lively, too, involving everyone in songs, cheers, and skits. As the fire dies down, the program also can become quieter and deeper, with the most important messages coming near the end.

An effective campfire is built on four S's:

- Showmanship
- Songs
- Skits
- Stories

Showmanship

Showmanship is the use of good communication skills to put sparkle and life into a gathering. Speaking well, using good body language, eye contact, etc. come together to make an effective program.

During the opening ceremony, it's showmanship that sets the tone of the whole program, but the end of a campfire is usually quiet and inspirational. The most important messages come as the embers of the fire are dying down, often including a Scoutmaster's Minute and an inspirational song. In between the opening and the closing, there will be plenty of opportunities for showmanship to add sparkle to the program through songs, skits, and stories.

Songs

There are many different types of songs that are appropriate for campfires: Scout songs, quiet songs, inspirational songs, songs that require audience action. Showmanship can help involve everyone in the singing.

The master of ceremonies invites one or more NYLT staff members to come forward and model good ways to lead songs.

Skits

Campfire skits can be fun and carry a message. There are plenty of ideas for skits found in Scouting America literature, other books about campfire skills, and on the internet. While these sources are good, even better are the Scouts' imaginations. Original skits can be tailor-made to fit local situations and recent events and can be extremely entertaining.

Stories

Storytelling is an art that almost anyone can acquire with practice. All you need is a good imagination, an appreciation of good stories, good communication skills, and a bit of showmanship.

The campfire stories generally fall into five types:

- Ghost
- Adventure
- Humorous
- Inspirational
- High-point

Ghost Stories. This is the most-asked-for type of campfire story but one that must be handled with care. Never try to scare an audience too badly with a ghost story. We want young people to feel at home in the woods. A ghastly story or disturbing descriptions can mar that experience for youth.

Adventure Stories. Perhaps the best of all campfire stories are adventure tales that stir the imagination. The adventure can be true or fictional, or perhaps a tall tale somewhere in between. A youth can describe an overnight adventure; a leader can relate some event of

 © Scouting America. For use in approved NYLT courses only.

importance from their past; a storyteller can retell the tales of explorers, heroes, scoundrels, or other real and imaginary characters.

Humorous Stories. American folklore is filled with fine and funny stories that lend themselves to being told or read around a campfire. Mark Twain's books and the stories of O. Henry, Robert Service, Bret Harte, and dozens of other American writers provide plenty of material.

Inspirational Stories. A story that inspires young people can be a very effective addition to a campfire program. There is no reason that an inspirational story cannot also have humorous elements or be an adventure tale. Look to the magazines published by Scouting America for stories, past and present, about inspiring individuals who have had a Scouting background.

High-point Stories. A campfire program should build toward a climax, an event that will top off the evening and make it a thing to remember. The high point of the program need not be elaborate, but it must be good. Among the possibilities are:

- An old-timer telling of adventure in far-off places
- A Scout telling of a jamboree experience, or tales of the Philmont trails
- A storyteller spinning a ghostly yarn
- A Scouter speaking for a quiet minute
- Someone telling the Baden-Powell story or the story of another important figure in Scouting or in local history

The master of ceremonies invites one or more NYLT staff to come forward and model good ways to tell a story.

Note on Appropriateness *of Songs, Skits, and Stories*

Songs, skits, and stories should never embarrass or demean anyone or any group of people. A good test of appropriateness is to hold the skit up against the Scout Law. Any skit that is not friendly, courteous, and kind has no place in a campfire program.

Songs, skits, and stories that involve any of the following are **NOT** appropriate and are **UNACCEPTABLE** for a Scout campfire:

- Name-calling, put-downs, hazing
- References to undergarments, nudity, or bodily functions
- Cross-gender impersonation (at any point in a skit)
- Derogatory references to or stereotyping of racial, ethnic, or cultural backgrounds; economic situations; or disabilities
- Sensitive social issues such as alcohol, drugs, gangs, guns, suicide, etc.
- Wasteful, ill-mannered, or improper use of food or water including wasting food in ANY way for comedic purpose
- Inside jokes that exclude some of those present
- Cultural exclusion—emphasis on the culture or faith of part of the group while ignoring the rest of the group
- Changing lyrics to patriotic songs ("America," "America the Beautiful," "God Bless America," "The Star-spangled Banner"), hymns, or other spiritual songs
- Embarrassing ANYONE—including staff or audience members (even if they are "in on it")

- Portraying violent behavior or any behavior not in line with the Guide to Safe Scouting (e.g., pointing “guns” at each other)
- Bathroom humor
- Water skits—NO ONE gets wet in any way (includes staff, even if they are “in on it”)
- Sexual overtones
- Anything that is not in keeping with the ideals of Scouting America

The Quest for the Meaning of Leadership

The master of ceremonies explains that a campfire can be an opportunity to share important information. They then invite the Scoutmaster to come forward. This could include both Scoutmasters for courses using the linked troop model; logistics should be worked out during staff development.

The Scoutmaster challenges the patrols to develop their presentations of the Quest for the Meaning of Leadership. Here is some sample wording:

“This has been a busy day for everyone, and we have accomplished a great deal. We have had a very good beginning to this National Youth Leadership Training course, and I look forward to a terrific experience for everyone in the days to come.

“There are many pieces to an NYLT course—lots of presentations, activities, and adventures. While each one is important, I want us all to keep in mind the bigger picture. What we are setting out on this week is a quest—a Quest for the Meaning of Leadership.

“Leadership means different things to different people. In the days to come, each patrol will be exploring leadership in many ways. The staff will be exploring leadership, too.

“To help us make the most of this experience, I want to challenge you this week to a search, a quest . . . a Quest for the Meaning of Leadership.

“Each day your understanding of leadership is going to change. You will add new information with every presentation. As you practice leadership yourselves, you will learn a great deal about what works and what is not effective. As you watch the staff modeling different leadership styles, you will see the best that NYLT leadership has to offer.

“To help us all make the most of this quest, I’m challenging each patrol to develop a presentation that shares their understanding of the meaning of leadership. The presentation can be a skit, a song, a piece of writing, even something you construct. Each patrol will deliver its presentation on the last day of this NYLT course.

“Daily planning and working on the presentation throughout the course will encourage patrol members to agree on how their patrol will proceed and to add each day’s learning to their presentation. The quartermaster will make available a variety of materials for patrols to use in their presentations if needed.

“Each patrol member is expected to contribute to their patrol’s success during the development of the presentation. The final product should clearly reflect the combined efforts of many individual talents.

 © Scouting America. For use in approved NYLT courses only.

“The Quest for the Meaning of Leadership is the great adventure of the coming days. It’s going to be fun, challenging, and full of new ideas. We are all in this together, and I’m looking forward to seeing what you all discover along the way.

“To set the tone for the quest, the staff has prepared a presentation of their own. Their quest has been a little different than yours will be. Theirs is the Quest for the Meaning of Teaching Leadership—their vision of successfully presenting the leadership concepts of the NYLT course.”

The Scoutmaster then invites NYLT staff to come forward and offer their presentation of the Quest for the Meaning of Teaching Leadership.

The staff’s presentation of their quest must be a good example of what will be expected of the patrols when they make their presentations later in the course. The staff presentation should be well-planned and interesting, and should offer real content.

Campfire Closing

The master of ceremonies tells participants that they have reached that time of the program when the fire is burning low and the hour is late. The presentation has been built on the four S’s of good program planning: showmanship, songs, skits, and stories. Participants will have had a great time, and perhaps will have received some seeds for thought and for long-term memories.

The master of ceremonies then calls on the Scoutmaster: “We’re going to use one more story to bring our campfire to a close. For the story, let’s use a Scoutmaster’s Minute.”

The Scoutmaster presents the Scoutmaster’s Minute:

“There is something magical about watching a flame. It can be a campfire, a candle, a lantern—the dancing light of fire draws us in and causes us to go a little deeper with our thoughts.

“What is a flame? What makes it possible? Three ingredients—heat, air, fuel.

“If I leave out any of those three, what happens? Without heat, the flame goes out. Without air, the fire is snuffed. Without fuel, the fire is starved.

“There is a fire that burns inside of each one of you, too. It is the fire of leadership. It is a flame that each of you can feel warming you. What do you need to kindle that flame of leadership, to build it from kindling and tinder into a strong, steady fire?

“As our campfire concludes, think about why you are attending this NYLT course. Dedicate yourself to making the most of the days that lie ahead. Stoke the fire of leadership burning in your soul. Let it grow and spread and light up your world.”

NATIONAL YOUTH LEADERSHIP TRAINING

THE CAMPFIRE PROGRAM PLANNER

How to use this sheet: Be sure that every feature of this campfire program upholds Scouting's highest traditions.

1. In a campfire planning meeting, fill in the top of the Campfire Program sheet (over).
2. On the Campfire Program Planner (below), list all units and individuals who will participate in the program.
3. Write down the name, description, and type of song, stunt, or story they have planned.
4. The MC organizes songs, stunts, and stories in a good sequence considering timing, variety, smoothness, and showmanship.
5. The master-of-the-campfire makes out the Campfire Program sheet (over).
6. Copies of the program are given to all participants.

Cheer Planner	Spot

Song Planner	Spot

Campfire Program Planner			
Group or Individual	Description	Type	Spot
Opening			
Closing			
Headliner	Main event		
Song leader			
Cheerleader			

 © Scouting America. For use in approved NYLT courses only.

 © Scouting America. For use in approved NYLT courses only.

CAMPFIRE PROGRAM

Place _____

Date _____

Time _____

Camp director's approval: _____

_____

Campers notified _____ Area set up by _____

Campfire planning meeting _____ _____

M. C. _____ Campfire built by _____

Song leader _____ Fire put out by _____

Cheermaster _____ Cleanup by _____

Spot	Title of Stunt, Song, or Story	By _____	Time
1	Opening—and firelighting		
2	Greeting—introduction	M.C.	
3	Sing— Yell—		
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			
16			
17			
18			
19			
20			
21			
22	Closing		

2